

Mains Master Program 2024: Art and Culture (GS1)

Handout 6: Visual Arts

Q. Buddhism and Jainism played a critical role in shaping ancient Indian art and literature. Illustrate.

Buddhism and Jainism were the two major heterodox schools that emerged in the 6th century BC. Ideas, beliefs and values of both religions interacted with and influenced various aspects of art and literature in Ancient India.

	Buddhism	Jainism
Architecture	Stupas – Bharhut, Sanchi Chaitya and Viharas – Karle, Kanheri	Caves: Udaygiri-Khandagiri Temples/Basadi/Derasar: Dilwara, Palitana etc.
Sculpture	Gandhara, Mathura, Amaravati	Mathura, Shravanbelgola, Ayagapata for worship
Painting	Ajanta decorations	Sittanvasal murals, Jain Pothe paintings
Literature	Pali: Tripitak, Milindpanho, Sanskrit: Buddhacharita, Lalitvistara	Prakrit: Purvas, Angas, Kalpasutra, Acharanga Sutra

In this way, besides religion and philosophy, Buddhism and Jainism helped in establishing & advancing new traditions in ancient Indian art, architecture and literature.

Practice Questions

Q. During the ancient India, different religious sects gave boost to architecture. Comment.

Q. Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss.



Q. Explain as to how the early Buddhist Stupa art, while using folk motifs and narratives and common cultural symbols, succeeded in transforming these themes for expounding the Buddhist ideals.

- **Folk Symbols**

- In Indic thought, the **lotus** is a symbol of purity and of rising above the mundane, of transcendence. In Buddhist art, it conveyed the ideal of the path to liberation and the blossoming of wisdom. Similarly, the **Bodhi tree** symbolized the awakening and the potential for spiritual realization within each individual.
- The **chakra** is an important symbol of cosmic order in Upanishadic thought. In Buddhism, it represents the turning of the Wheel of Law.
- **Lion**, a symbol of royalty was used for depicting Shakya-Simha while **bull**, an important animal related to fertility rituals was repurposed to depict the birth of Buddha. Similarly, **elephant**, which was the vehicle of Indra, now represents the conception of Buddha.
- Commonly known **mudras and asanas** also communicated Buddhist ideals and principles.

- **Mythological Narratives and folk deities:**

- **Yakshas and yakshis:** Images of yakshas and yakshis, since time immemorial, embody the spirit of nature and reminds of the divinity that underlies all. They represent the protection of nature and its great fertility, which ensures the continuance of life. Sculpture of **Kubera**, who symbolises abundance, and **Yakshi** holding a branch of the Asoka tree above her can be seen on Stupas.
- **Lakshmi:** The deity of prosperity and abundance, Lakshmi, can also be seen on the Vedika of Bharhut and Sanchi, either with lotus or with elephants.
- Similarly, **Naga deities** originally served to keep us conscious of the power, the protection and the fertility of nature. On Sanchi stupa, they are shown in various sculptures as guardians of Stupa.

- **The Jataka narratives** also carried forward pre-Buddhist folklores as were sculpted at Sanchi and Bharhut.

- These stories were now used to exemplify the rules of conduct in everyday life. They conveyed messages of **compassion, morality, and ethical conduct**. Thus, these were transformed into teaching tools.
- The world of Jatakas makes no distinction between the life of man and that of the animals, plants and trees. The humans are shown in **harmony with nature**. The stories of the Buddha, in his various **avatars in the form of different animals**, naturally depict the artist's belief of the **whole of creation being linked intimately**.

- As stupas also served as focal points for devotional practices, ritual practices like **circumambulation, offering flowers, lighting lamps, and chanting mantras became popular forms of worship**. These rituals created a sense of community and reinforced the ideals of Buddhism.

Practice Questions:

Q. Gandhara School of art was as much in debt to the Romans as it was to the Greeks. Explain.

Q. More than Gandhara style, it is the Mathura style of sculptures that represented Indian cultural ethos. Do you agree?

Q. Among the ancient sculptural traditions, Amravati school of art was unique in its style. Discuss.

Q. Explain the evolution of cave architecture during ancient period of Indian history.

Q. The evolution of rock-cut architecture in India reflects changing religious influences. Discuss.

Q. The rock-cut architecture represents one of the most important sources of our knowledge of early Indian art and history. Discuss.

Q. Discuss how the visual arts were used to propagate the ideas of Puranic Hinduism in ancient India.

Puranic Hinduism is a collection of diverse beliefs which emerged from Vedic Brahmanism by absorbing many local religious cults, idols, deities, shrines, avatars, vratas and pilgrimages. These ideas and stories were in turn disseminated through various visual artforms like sculpture, painting, and temple architecture. This process reinforced religious beliefs, promoted bhakti, and educated people about the cultural heritage of Hinduism.

- **The tradition of temple architecture** began during Gupta era, to promote the idea of bhakti. From Vishnu Temple of Deogarh (MP), it continued in early medieval Kailashnath Temple (Ellora), Khajuraho and Konark temples etc.
 - Temple architecture was imbued with **symbolism of sacred geometry**, reflecting the Puranic **cosmology**.
 - Temples were not only the places of worship but also served as **living monuments** that told the Puranic **mythological episodes with wall carvings**.
- **Sculpture:**
 - **Development of iconography** made it easy to identify various gods and connect them Puranic narrative. E.g. Four-armed Vishnu with shankha-chakra-gada-padma.
 - **Narrative sculptures** brought the mythological world of the Puranas to life. E.g. Panels on the walls of Kailasa cave represent stories from Ramayana and Mahabharata.
 - **Popularization of Avataravada** in Vaishnavism. E.g. Varaha avatar panel at Udaygiri cave (MP)
 - **Development of other sects**
 - Shaivism: Massive sculpture of Trimurti Shiva at Elephanta cave (MH)
 - Shakti: Large and lean Mahishasurmardini panel at Badami cave (KN)
 - **Temple-based Bhakti:**
 - Bronze sculptures of Alvar and Nayanar saints during the Chola dynasty indicate the royal patronage to the Puranic tradition inside temples.
- **Painting: Murals** at Badami caves or Chola temples depict various Puranic stories.

This diverse set of visual art continues to propagate ideas of Puranic Hinduism even today and keeps our link to our past.

Practice Questions

Q. Chola architecture represents a high watermark in the evolution of temple architecture. Discuss.

Q. Do you agree with the view that the form and content of temple architecture in South India between c. A.D. 750 and 1200 were products of a specific economic and political milieu?

Q. What role did the temples play in the economic and cultural life of South India? Elaborate.

Q. How will you explain that medieval Indian temple sculptures represent the social life of those days.